

MARINE CONSERVATION

We cherish the beauty and diversity of life in the oceans, but the future of humanity may also depend on their health. People need to eat, so if the fish stocks that supply up to 20 percent of the world's protein-rich food disappear, then many people may starve. If we allow marine ecosystems to collapse, we have no way of knowing how this might affect life elsewhere. Marine conservation is essential if we are to prevent such destruction. It might not deal with the major challenge of climate change, but if it helps keep the oceans healthy, the oceans may keep the planet healthy, too.



◀ QUOTAS AND TREATIES

Many fisheries are now controlled by international treaties, with each boat having a catch quota that it cannot exceed. Some boats like these in Newfoundland, in Canada, have stopped working altogether, causing hardship for the local people. Yet this is better than the complete destruction of the fish that this industry relies on. Eventually, such treaties should allow fish stocks to recover, but this may take a long time.

MARINE RESERVES ▶

In some places, sea areas have been set aside as marine reserves. Fishing and other damaging activities are prohibited, allowing their wildlife to flourish, multiply, and spread into nearby waters. This can dramatically improve both the variety and number of fish, so "no fishing" zones may make fishing in neighboring areas easier and more profitable.



IMPROVED TECHNOLOGY

For decades, people have been using better equipment to catch more fish. Improved technology can also help with conservation, by making sure that only the target species are caught. The baited longlines that hook albatrosses, for example, can be equipped with bird-scapers like these, or streamed from the boats underwater so the birds cannot see the bait. Specially designed fishing nets may enable dolphins to escape entanglement and drowning. The problem, however, is not designing the equipment, but getting people to use it when they are out of sight of land.

